

AMERICAN MAHJONG (CLASSIC)

American Mahjong is the distinctly American adaptation of Chinese Mahjong, shaped by a specific chain of people and events between 1920 and 1937. Joseph Park Babcock, a Standard Oil representative in Shanghai, began importing Mahjong sets to the United States in large numbers around 1920 and wrote simplified English rules — the **Red Book** — to make the game accessible to American players.

The 1920s saw a nationwide Mahjong craze. By the mid-1920s, so many regional variations had developed that the **1924 Standardization Committee** consolidated the *American Official Laws of Mah-Jongg*. The National Mah Jongg League published its own *Official American Rules* in 1935. Both sources form the basis of this Classic variant.

In 1937, the NMJL introduced its annually-changing scorecard of winning hands, which has defined modern American Mahjong ever since. **American Mahjong (Classic)** preserves the pre-card-era game: the same 152-tile set, the same Charleston, the same joker rules — but with fixed classical hand patterns rather than a subscription card.

THE TILE SET (152 TILES)

Category	Tiles	Detail
Dots (Circles)	36	Ranks 1–9, 4 tiles each
Bamboo (Bams)	36	Ranks 1–9, 4 tiles each; the 1-Bam tile traditionally shows a crane
Characters (Craks)	36	Ranks 1–9, 4 tiles each
Winds	16	East/South/West/North, 4 each
Dragons	12	Red (), Green (), White (/ Soap), 4 each
Flowers	4	Plum, Orchid, Chrysanthemum, Bamboo (numbered 1–4)
Seasons	4	Spring, Summer, Autumn, Winter (numbered 1–4)
Jokers	8	Wild; may substitute for any tile in a meld
Total	152	

American Mahjong sets are identified by Arabic numerals on all tiles and English letters for wind direction (E/S/W/N).

MELDS AND TILE GROUPS

GROUP	TILES	NOTES
Pair	2 identical	Cannot include a joker
Pung	3 identical	May include jokers
Kong	4 identical	May include jokers
Quint	5 identical	Requires jokers
Sextet	6 identical	Requires jokers
Sequence	3+ consecutive, same suit	May include jokers

JOKERS

Jokers are wild and may substitute for any tile within a pung, kong, quint, sextet, or sequence. Restrictions:

- ♦ A joker **cannot** be used in a pair
- ♦ A joker **cannot** be passed during the Charleston
- ♦ Any player on their own turn may **exchange** a real matching tile for a joker in an exposed meld, taking the joker into their hand

SETUP

- 1 Shuffle all 152 tiles face-down. Each player builds a row of **19 tiles stacked two high** (38 tiles per wall section, 152 total forming a square wall)
- 2 Roll dice to determine **East** (dealer). East rolls again to find the **break point** in the wall
- 3 Deal clockwise from the break point: each player draws **13 tiles**; East draws **14**
- 4 Tiles are held upright on a rack, hidden from opponents

THE CHARLESTON

The Charleston is the defining pre-game ritual of American Mahjong, conducted before the first discard. It does not exist in any Asian Mahjong variant.

First Charleston:

PASS	DIRECTION	NOTES
1st	Right	Each player passes 3 unwanted tiles face-down to the right
2nd	Across	Each player passes 3 unwanted tiles face-down to the player opposite
3rd	Left	Each player passes 3 unwanted tiles face-down to the left; blind pass permitted

Blind pass: On the third pass of each Charleston, a player may take 1, 2, or 3 of the tiles just received and pass them on without looking at them.

Second Charleston (optional): If all four players agree, a second Charleston proceeds in reverse: Left → Across → Right. The same blind pass rule applies to the last pass.

Courtesy Pass (optional): After the Charleston(s), players may agree to exchange 0–3 tiles with the player across. Both must agree on the number before passing. No blind tiles.

GAMEPLAY

East discards a tile face-up to start play. Thereafter play proceeds clockwise.

On your turn:

1 Draw the top tile from the wall

2 Discard one tile from your hand face-up to the centre, or declare **Mahjong** if your hand is complete

Claiming a discard: Any player may claim the most recent discard (before the next player draws) to complete a meld or declare Mahjong. Announce the claim, take the tile, expose the completed meld on the rack, and discard. Mahjong claim takes priority over all other claims.

Discards may only be claimed to complete an exposed meld or declare Mahjong — not to draw ahead in sequence.

FLOWERS AND SEASONS

Flowers and Seasons are bonus tiles. When drawn, place the tile face-up on the rack and draw a replacement from the **dead wall** (the reserved end tiles). They score bonus points and are not part of the hand structure.

WINNING

A player wins by declaring Mahjong with a complete valid hand.

Standard hand: 4 melds + 1 pair = 14 tiles (plus any declared kongs).

Classic Special Hands:

HAND	DESCRIPTION
All Pungs	Four pungs + one pair; no sequences
All Sequences	Four sequences + one pair; no pungs
All One Suit	Entire hand (excluding honours) in a single suit
Honour Hand	Hand composed entirely of winds and dragons
Mixed Honour	One suit plus winds and/or dragons
All Green	2, 3, 4, 6, 8 Bamboo and Green Dragon only
Nine Gates	1-1-1-2-3-4-5-6-7-8-9-9 in one suit + any tile of that suit

SCORING

The winning player collects from all three opponents. The player whose discard completes a winning hand pays double.

ELEMENT	POINTS
Winning (base)	20
Self-draw win	+10
Each pung of simples (2-8)	+2
Each pung of terminals/honours	+4
Each kong (exposed)	×2 on pung value
Each kong (concealed)	×4 on pung value
Matching flower/season	+4
All Pungs hand	×2 multiplier
All One Suit hand	×4 multiplier
Fully concealed hand	×2 multiplier

Minimum to win: **25 points**.

END OF HAND

If all wall tiles are drawn without a Mahjong declaration, the hand is a **draw** (goulash) – no points are exchanged. East retains the deal on a draw; otherwise the deal passes left.

ATtribution

Sources (all public domain):

- ♦ Joseph Park Babcock, *Babcock's Rules for Mah-Jongg: The Red Book of Rules* (1920, revised 1923)
- ♦ 1924 Standardization Committee, *American Official Laws of Mah-Jongg*
- ♦ NMJL, *Official American Rules* (1935, pre-card era)